

Keeping up with the Joneses

Keeping up with the Joneses is an old phrase that refers to the constant pressure of “keeping up” with the social status and wealth of one’s friends and neighbours.

Research shows that this phrase originated with the Jones family, a wealthy and **prominent** New Yorker who began building **elegant** and grand **mansions**. In response, other New Yorkers tried to **outdo** them by constructing even more **elaborate** homes in the Hudson Valley.

In 1853, Elizabeth S. Jones built Wyndcliffe, a 24-room **ornate** mansion designed in the style of a Scottish castle. Soon, other wealthy families started building **extravagant estates** to **showcase** their wealth. This competition **gave rise to** the phrase “keeping up with the Joneses.”

Interestingly, the **sentiment** behind this phrase **has persisted** even to this day. I have observed similar **scenarios** within my circle of friends. I remember, Anita and Sheila had been best friends for years. When Anita bought a beautiful three-bedroom house in an **upscale neighbourhood**, she couldn’t wait to show her house to Sheila. “This place is amazing!” remarked Sheila as she admired the high **ceilings** and designer kitchen. It must have **cost a fortune!**”

Anita **beamed**. “It was a bit **pricey**, but totally worth it. The neighborhood is great, and the schools are **top notch**.”

That evening Sheila went home feeling **restless** and **envious** of her friend. She and her husband had been considering upgrading their townhouse. Within three weeks, they found a house that was much bigger and grander than their friend’s, located in a very upscale neighbourhood. However, they **ended up** spending more than they had budgeted. While they achieved their goal of finding a more impressive home, the financial **strain** left them constantly stressed.

It took me by surprise, when I read in the Forbes magazine that the average size of a home has tripled in the past 50 years, even with the family size consistently getting smaller. In addition, one in 10 Americans have to rent a storage unit, because they can’t fit all of their stuff inside their giant homes.

Here is another scenario I observed. **David**, one of our friends, **was ecstatic** when he bought a luxury car. However, his excitement was **short lived**, when a friend arrived in a Mercedes - a more expensive car and a true status symbol. Suddenly, the pride David once felt began to **fade**. The same car he had proudly shown off to his neighbours and friends no longer seemed impressive. Before long, he stopped parking it outside his garage, as what once brought him joy now felt **overshadowed**.

There are many similar **instances** that we observe daily. We take **immense** pleasure in **portraying** our best moments in life to the world, be it an expensive **vacation**, designer clothes, the latest gadgets or our busy social calendar. We are constantly trying to **flaunt** our perfect lifestyle to the world, especially on social media. Social media is one of the most powerful sources of displaying our choicest moments, which puts us in constant pressure and competition with each other. But why do we behave this way?

One can argue that it's just human behaviour, influenced by **peer pressure**, **consumerism**, **commercialisation**, social media-or all of the above. However, there should be an understanding that this **facade** can make us feel inadequate, burdened with financial stress with **mounting debt** and emotional stress in the form of **anxiety** and depression. It is like two parallel lines endlessly chasing each other, never quite meeting. Does it ever end? Maybe—when we stop measuring our worth against others and start defining fulfilment on our terms.

Instead of chasing status symbols, we should focus on what genuinely brings happiness—strong relationships, meaningful experiences, and financial stability. **Breaking** free from this cycle **requires** shifting our **perspective**, redefining success, and **embracing gratitude**. After all, wealth is not about what we own but about how fulfilled we feel.

The moment we stop comparing and start living for ourselves, we finally win the race that never truly existed.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

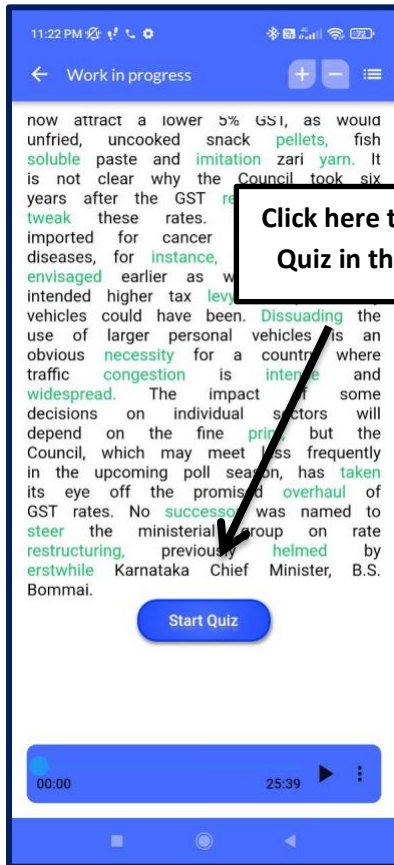
1. **Keeping up with the Joneses** (phrase) - Social competition, Status rivalry, Material competition, Neighborly one-upmanship, Conspicuous consumption दूसरों के स्तर पर रहने की होड़
2. **Prominent** (adjective) - Notable, Distinguished, Eminent, Conspicuous, Renowned प्रमुख
3. **Elegant** (adjective) - Graceful, Stylish, Sophisticated, Refined, Polished सुंदर
4. **Mansion** (noun) - Villa, Manor, Estate, Palace, Chateau हवेली
5. **Outdo** (verb) - Surpass, Excel, Beat, Eclipse, Top पीछे छोड़ देना
6. **Elaborate** (adjective) - Intricate, Detailed, Complex, Fancy, Ornate विस्तृत
7. **Ornate** (adjective) - Decorated, Embellished, Adorned, Fancy, Baroque अलंकृत
8. **Extravagant** (adjective) - Lavish, Excessive, Wasteful, Opulent, Prodigal फिजूलखर्च
9. **Estate** (noun) - Property, Landholding, Domain, Acres, Grounds जायदाद
10. **Showcase** (verb) - Display, Exhibit, Present, Feature, Highlight प्रदर्शित करना
11. **Give rise to** (phrase) - Cause, Generate, Produce, Create, Spark उत्पन्न करना
12. **Sentiment** (noun) - Emotion, Feeling, Attitude, Opinion, View भावना
13. **Persist** (verb) - Continue, Endure, Persevere, Last, Remain बने रहना
14. **Scenario** (noun) - Situation, Circumstance, Case, Context, Setting परिदृश्य
15. **Upscale** (adjective) - Luxury, High-end, Exclusive, Premium, Posh उच्चस्तरीय
16. **Neighbourhood** (noun) - Locality, District, Community, Area, Vicinity पड़ोस
17. **Ceiling** (noun) - Roof, Overhead, Covering, Canopy, Dome छत
18. **Cost** (verb) - Price, Value, Amount to, Require, Set back कीमत होना
19. **Fortune** (noun) - Wealth, Riches, Affluence, Prosperity, Assets संपत्ति
20. **Beam** (verb) - Smile, Grin, Radiate, Glow, Shine चमकना
21. **Pricey** (adjective) - Expensive, Costly, High-priced, Dear, Premium महंगा
22. **Top notch** (adjective) - Excellent, Superb, Outstanding, First-rate, Premium उत्कृष्ट
23. **Restless** (adjective) - Uneasy, Fidgety, Agitated, Anxious, Nervous बेचैन
24. **Envious** (adjective) - Jealous, Covetous, Resentful, Green-eyed, Grudging ईर्ष्यालु

25. **End up** (phrasal verb) - Conclude, Finish, Wind up, Result, Terminate अंत में पहुँचना
26. **Strain** (noun) - Stress, Pressure, Tension, Burden, Anxiety तनाव
27. **Ecstatic** (adjective) - Elated, Thrilled, Overjoyed, Delighted, Euphoric उत्साहित
28. **Short lived** (adjective) - Brief, Temporary, Fleeting, Transient, Ephemeral अल्पकालिक
29. **Fade** (verb) - Dim, Dull, Pale, Disappear, Vanish फीका पड़ना
30. **Overshadowed** (adjective) - Eclipse, Dwarf, Dominate, Outshine, Surpass ग्रहण लगना
31. **Instance** (noun) - Example, Case, Occurrence, Illustration, Sample उदाहरण
32. **Immense** (adjective) - Huge, Vast, Enormous, Gigantic, Colossal विशाल
33. **Portray** (verb) - Depict, Represent, Describe, Illustrate, Render चित्रित करना
34. **Vacation** (noun) - Holiday, Break, Getaway, Retreat, Leave छुट्टी
35. **Flaunt** (verb) - Show off, Display, Parade, Exhibit, Boast दिखावा करना
36. **Peer pressure** (noun) - when you are influenced by other people (your peers) to act in a certain way साथियों का दबाव
37. **Consumerism** (noun) - Materialism, Commercialism, Acquisition, Consumption, Buying उपभोक्तावाद
38. **Commercialization** (noun) - Monetization, Marketing, Commodification, Exploitation, Merchandising व्यावसायीकरण
39. **Façade** (noun) - Front, Appearance, Show, Mask, Pretense मुखौटा
40. **Mounting** (adjective) - Increasing, Growing, Rising, Escalating, Accumulating बढ़ता हुआ
41. **Debt** (noun) - Loan, Liability, Obligation, Arrears, Indebtedness कर्ज
42. **Anxiety** (noun) - Worry, Nervousness, Unease, Apprehension, Stress चिंता
43. **Perspective** (noun) - Viewpoint, Outlook, Angle, Standpoint, Position दृष्टिकोण
44. **Embrace** (verb) - Accept, Adopt, Welcome, Hug, Cherish अपनाना
45. **Gratitude** (noun) - Thankfulness, Appreciation, Gratefulness, Recognition, Acknowledgment कृतज्ञता

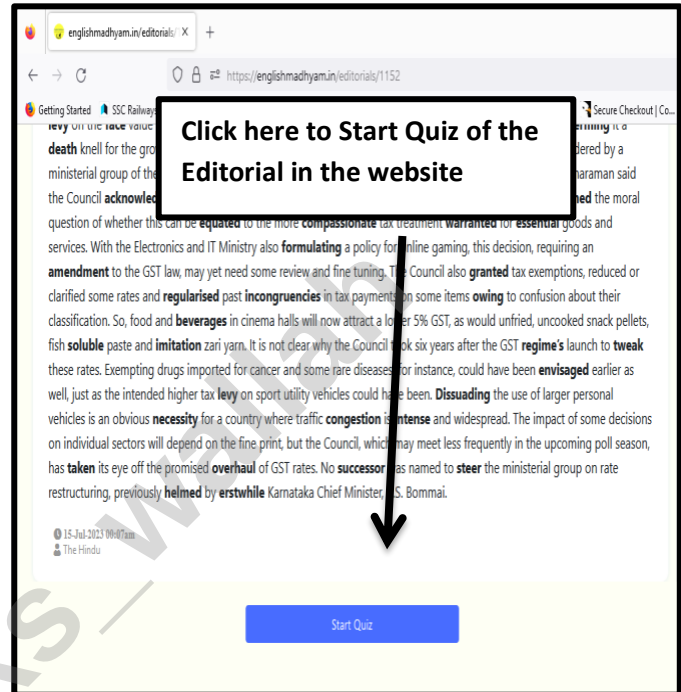
Summary of the Editorial

1. The phrase "*keeping up with the Joneses*" refers to the pressure to match the wealth and status of peers.
2. It originated from wealthy New Yorkers competing with the affluent Jones family's extravagant mansions in the 1800s.
3. Elizabeth S. Jones built *Wyndcliffe*, a grand 24-room mansion, sparking a trend of lavish estates among the rich.
4. The phrase remains relevant today, reflecting ongoing social competition.
5. An example: Anita's upscale home made her friend Sheila envious, leading Sheila to buy a costlier house beyond her budget.
6. Financial strain from such comparisons causes stress and dissatisfaction.
7. Home sizes have tripled in 50 years, despite shrinking family sizes.
8. Many Americans rent storage units due to excessive possessions.
9. Another example: David's pride in his luxury car faded when a friend bought a more expensive Mercedes.
10. People constantly showcase wealth—luxury trips, gadgets, clothes—to project a perfect lifestyle.
11. Social media amplifies this competition, pressuring people to display curated, idealized lives.
12. The behavior stems from peer pressure, consumerism, and commercialization.
13. The cycle leads to feelings of inadequacy, financial stress, debt, anxiety, and depression.
14. True fulfillment comes from relationships, meaningful experiences, and financial stability—not material possessions.
15. Happiness is achieved by stopping comparisons, redefining success, and living authentically.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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